

What else to watch: *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920, pp.24–27) ■ *Faust* (1926) ■ *The Lodger* (1927) ■ *Wings* (1927) ■ *Street Angel* (1928) ■ *Man with a Movie Camera* (1929) ■ *City Lights* (1931, pp.38–41) ■ *A Star Is Born* (1937)

sensationalist story of sex, death, violence, and betrayal. But will the man commit murder? With her black bob, sleek satin dress, and smoldering cigarette, the woman from the city embodies the amorality of the metropolis, while the man is a symbol of rustic innocence. The viewer assumes that *Sunrise* will be a chronicle of corruption; at one point the woman appears devil-like on the man's shoulder, urging him to sin. The man invites his wife to take a boat ride, but when the moment comes to drown her, he can't go through with it.

The man hesitates, the wife escapes, and when he catches up with her, the pair find themselves on a tram bound for the city. Unable to discuss what has happened at the lake for fear of being overheard, they stay on the tram.

City awakening

This is where *Sunrise* surprises us. The metropolis has a magical effect on the man and his wife as they spend the day wandering through its vertiginous throng, thrown together in a touching, accidental second courtship.

Yet there is still much drama ahead, and more unforgettable sights: crowds through which the camera swoops, street carnivals,

Unable to go through with the murder, the man follows his wife to a tram, and they both end up heading for the city.



Sunrise was one of the first movies with sound effects, but its innovations were largely overlooked.

and strange hallucinogenic patterns in the bright lights. Danger, too, will reappear, the past not so easily escaped. And all of it is made with the kind of ambition—

Murnau's "city" was made up of vast, complex, hugely expensive sets—that has led many to see *Sunrise* as a pinnacle of the silent movies, a beautiful last waltz.

Last sunrise

Sunrise plays like a montage of the silent era's greatest hits, a flickering carousel of melodrama, suspense, horror, spectacle, slapstick, and tragedy. The US release was given

Murnau's films are gorgeous, and *Sunrise* is no exception. Its luscious black-and-white photography and sweeping camera moves haven't aged.

Pamela Hutchinson
The Guardian

a Movietone soundtrack, which added piglet squeals, traffic horns, and other clunky effects, but the movie doesn't need these to bring its world to life. "Wherever the sun rises and sets," says the closing title card, "in the city's turmoil or under the open sky on the farm, life is much the same; sometimes bitter, sometimes sweet." ■

